"I think some of the best things in life happen by accident," says celebrated couturier Tarun Tahiliani. Over the past three decades of his illustrious run, he has scripted several milestones—each of which can be credited for reinforcing the 'India Modern' aesthetic much before it became a buzzword.

Tahiliani's design language has always been rooted in Indian craft. So it's hardly surprising that one of his works—a Pichwai called 'The Shikargah'—that was earlier showcased at the India Art Fair 2024 will now be part of the Homo Faber exhibition in Venice in September during the biennale season.

Tahiliani admits to having drifted to embroideries over time but he continues to be excited about the possibilities of everyday wear

'The Shikargah' is akin to the mythical Garden of Eden, as observed through intricately detailed *jaalis* on a door framing its archway. Within this enchanting scene, fantastical flora and fauna harmoniously co-exist. It employs techniques like the Dob (the art of embroidering on paper or cardboard inserts) alongside French knots, mother-of-pearl hand carving and layering. "Embroidery represents the highest form of Indian craft, and our craftsmen are the best in the world. It's also partly economic because a lot of people from villages do not get to go to school...so this is the traditional craft of surface embellishment," says Tahiliani.

He recalls the time during the first Covid lockdown when uncertainty loomed large over the future of migrant labour. To keep the artisans busy and offer them reassurance, the idea of making wall hangings was conceived. "This wasn't an altruistic project, but it certainly gave us something to think about. We painted motifs, printed the designs, experimented with them and, eventually, I went to this master craftsman in Lucknow who runs a unit in aari embroidery," he shares.

"We then brought in mother-of-pearl from Banaras, and a supplier in Jaipur who would hand-cut these champa flowers and shells. It somehow became a fun collaboration. There was no financial motive or immediate plan on what to do with this," Tahiliani elaborates.

When they came out of the lockdown and the Tarun Tahiliani Design Studio began using this technique on lehengas, it became their top-selling collection. Eventually, the embroidery was spotlighted on walls at their stores. "It helped look at embroidery organically, not just as something meant for clothes, but as an art form on its own," he says.

Tahiliani is not just a 'master of drapes'—a moniker he has earned over time—but also a storyteller par excellence. His recent commemorative volume, *Journey to India Modern*, co-authored

